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Thomas More Doesn't Know Me

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Thomas More Doesn't Know Me

By Sarah Weiner

"I would rather be honest than clever." Thomas More said that in Utopia. He's a philosopher. Well, if I'm being honest, I have an issue with honesty. It's not that I lie to people. I mostly just lie to myself. Denial is more than just a river in Egypt, you know [**buh dum tsh* finger guns*].* Ok so here I go—honesty time. I guess I should start by not hiding my emotions behind 10 layers of sarcasm and puns… [*considering this*] no that's too far. I'm not ready for that level of sincerity. Actually, if we're on the topic of philosophy then here's some relevant honesty for you—studying philosophy doesn't make you special and it definitely doesn't mean you're morally superior to anyone else. [*Getting heated*] Further, Jean-Paul Sartre is a piss poor writer—yeah, I said it—and as much as I enjoyed reading Utopia; why couldn't Thomas have just gotten to the damn point instead of burying his true feelings about communism under a fat load of syntax variations and convoluted Latin bullshit. That's not very "honest" of you, Tommy. How can you possibly lecture me about honesty when you pull stunts like that? [mockingly] "I'd rather be honest than clever," oh please; of course, you want to be clever. Not just that—you want everyone in the room to know just how clever you are. Why else would you become a philosopher? I hate philosophers, [calming herself] but I get it. Being able to insult Sartre and quote More in the same breath does make you feel powerful which is a nice change because I often don't feel very powerful at all…it's the opposite really. That's half the reason I started studying philosophy in the first place. Power and spite. [*laughing a little*] Pleasant, I know.

[*reluctantly- she clearly does not want to talk about this*] My best friend—uh well—he was my best friend. We don't talk much anymore. He's the one who introduced me to philosophy. Mickey Krone. I usually just called him Krone or Mick, *[starting to have fun with it*] but he was also K-dog, Mick Jagger, Mickey Mouse, Mickereno, OR when I wanted to make him extra uncomfortable I would call him Mick-daddy. The internet really ruined that word for us, but I have the

sense of humor of a 9-volt battery, so I still think it's funny. [remembering fondly] I remember exactly how we first met. I went to a party with some friends. There were only about 25 people there, but the way he ran at me when I walked in…you would think I was the hot new toy on black Friday. It was startling, but I appreciated the boldness of it. I'd like to say we had a pleasant conversation but Mickey… he's an intense guy. I don't mind that. I can be intense too, [this is funny to her] but that conversation felt more like an interrogation of my political views. He had this spark in his eye when he was challenging me. It was like he was trying make me angry, but it wasn't really working because I genuinely enjoy debating policy despite us having polar opposite views. I'm capitalist scum and he's one step short of a dirty communist, but that didn't matter. It was fun and he's easy to talk to. Later, we raided the kitchen to make peanut butter sandwiches.

Now since I'm trying to make Thomas More proud, I should be honest and admit that I had a crush on him pretty much then on [defending what she just said] but it's not like I wanted to be his girlfriend. He already had one of those which shouldn't be surprising. He's a real smooth talker. Every word out of his mouth was like a dare, pushing you to expand your mind; to think more critically. And he would listen so intently you could be fooled into believing you were saying something profound and absurdly clever even if it was just what you ate for breakfast that morning.

But if you really want to know about Mickey, you need to see him in his full form. I snuck into a round to watch him debate once. I technically wasn't supposed to be there but come on! How could I resist? The other team was running their mouths like lightning, fumbling with their papers. They were messy. Not our boy, Mick though. His language was chosen carefully and deliberately—every move, pre-meditated. It was like watching a nature documentary where the black widow waits in silence as her captured prey flails desperately before striking with perfect accuracy and grace. It was fascinating to watch him make the other team hate him and the judges fall in love with him at the same time. [catching herself] Ah but Mr. Thomas More says honesty is more important that cleverness so I should also mention that he was constantly trying to psycho-analyze me which is super annoying especially because he was usually wrong, and it just made him sound like a pretentious douche nozzle. He got it in his head that just because he's a philosophy major, he automatically understands me better than I understand

myself. [*trying to be fair*] Even still, he is the smartest person I know…or at least he was really good at pretending to be. That's the thing about philosophy. It makes it hard to tell if the guy laying upside on your couch ranting on Cicero is actually a genius or just a very talented con artist.

[*really does not want to get into this*] I guess it's time for me to explain what happened, right? Why we don't speak anymore. I've stalled long enough. It was just about a year ago now. I was having a royally crap week. Life was hitting me with everything it had: school stress, friend drama, family chaos, and I was <u>not</u> handling it well. So, Mick came over to my apartment to cheer me up.

I'm lying on the floor having a break down (as I do) and Mick's sitting next to me telling me what I'm feeling (as he does) and I'm just hanging onto every word hoping it will ground me for a moment. Except, I feel like I'm drowning and he's really less of an anchor and more like driftwood. Then…he stops talking. That's alarming because he loves the sound of his own voice, [it's like she's experiencing this all over again] but he was just sitting there staring at me…until…well he kissed me. I think I was supposed to be happy. I mean, he was my best friend whom I also had feelings for. That's like something out of a frickin' John Greene novel. But I was not in the right headspace for this to happen let alone deal with his pissed off girlfriend. So, I pushed him off. I told him no, and he laughed at me. He <u>laughed</u> at me. " Oh come on, Em. I know you like me. You should really be more honest with yourself" [*shocked, infuriated*] I should really be more honest with myself? Spoken like a true philosopher. That's the thing about Mick…once he decides how you feel, that's that. There's no telling him otherwise. No matter how loudly you scream "how can you possibly know how I feel!? I told you no. Why is that not enough?" he won't hear you. He decided I wanted him…and his judgement is final. Like I said, he's an intense guy and sometimes…it's scary. Watching the black widow is only fun until you're the one caught in the web.

Everything that followed is fuzzy. I couldn't tell you exactly what happened if I wanted to. I just froze. I couldn't move. I couldn't speak. I used to hear stories about women who were raped, and their abuser was set free because the woman didn't fight back. [letting this sink in] I understand that now. Then, there was the pain. If I didn't know any better, I might have thought someone lit me on fire. I wish someone had. Then there was nothing. Just black and it was over.

He accidentally left behind his copy of “Being and Nothingness”. (You know that 500 page, needlessly complicated trash fire of a book written by none other than Jean-Paul Sartre.) I feel like there’s some irony hidden in that. There were little notes and things written in the margins. I don’t know why, but I read it. It made me feel like I was doing something productive I guess…I felt like I had control again, but that was really just me lying to myself.

We didn’t speak for almost a month after that. Eventually I got up the nerve to confront him…but he didn’t understand why I was upset. I told him he raped me. He disagreed. “You’re just confused. If you had been more honest with yourself from the beginning, you wouldn’t feel this way,” that’s what he said. [feeling defeated] Your friends aren’t supposed to do this to you. Strangers are the ones I should be afraid of.

[*taking a breath*] I would like to say I was shocked that he would treat me like this…but in hindsight, it makes sense. There’s another quote from my good ol’ friend Tommy that says, “as robbers prove sometimes gallant soldiers, so soldiers often prove brave robbers”. [*almost laughing but bitter*] I was standing around all this time with my head up my ass thinking I had a soldier on my side while the bastard was robbing me blind. In all seriousness, I didn’t know him as well as I thought I did, but now? Now I see him for what he is. Mickey Krone is a con artist and a damn good one. So good, in fact, that he conned himself. He spends all his time telling others who they are and how they feel so he never has to face who <u>he</u> is and how <u>he</u> feels. I pity him more than anything. He can lie all he wants, but deep down he knows what he did, and he has to live with himself. I used to obsess over what happened—trying desperately to think of something I could have done to stop it, but what does that matter anymore? There’s no happy ending to this story. There can’t be. Even if more people had believed me and Mickey got what he deserved, I was still raped by the guy I trusted more than anyone. I was raped, and nothing can change that. All that’s left is to move forward. It’s time for me to be my own “gallant soldier”. So here I am—speaking my truth, being honest. And honestly, I think Thomas More would be proud of me. Eh but who cares what he thinks? [*with a smirk*] He’s just a philosopher.